

Clinical Dialogue Transcript — Addiction

Therapist Model:	gemini-flash-latest
Patient Model:	llama-3.1-8b-instant
Condition / DSM-5:	Addiction
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Total Dialogue Turns:	21

THERAPIST (Turn 1)

Hi, thanks for coming in today. What's been going on for you lately?

PATIENT (Turn 2)

My partner basically made me come. I don't think it's as big a deal as they're making it out to be, honestly.

THERAPIST (Turn 3)

I really appreciate you being honest with me about that right off the bat. It can feel pretty frustrating—and a bit awkward—to be sitting in a room like this just because someone else insisted on it.

First, I want to make sure you know that even though your partner asked you to come, this space belongs to *you*, not them. You're in the driver's seat here, and we don't have to talk about anything you don't want to.

If you're open to sharing, though, what is it that your partner feels is such a big deal? I'd really like to hear how things look from your perspective.

PATIENT (Turn 4)

They say I'm drinking too much, that it's affecting my job and they're tired of covering for me when I'm hungover. But I just feel like...I don't know, it's just a drink or two after work to unwind, right? It's not like I'm a drunk or anything.

THERAPIST (Turn 5)

That makes a lot of sense. When most people hear words like "drinking problem" or "drunk," they picture someone who has hit rock bottom or whose whole life is falling apart. So when you're just trying to decompress after a long, stressful workday, hearing your partner talk about it like it's a huge crisis can feel really unfair—and maybe a bit frustrating.

It's completely normal to want a way to unwind. At the same time, I'm hearing two very different stories here: on one side, it feels to you like a totally reasonable way to take the edge off. But on the other side, your partner is feeling stressed out, talking about hangovers, and worried about your job.

I'm curious—setting aside what your partner thinks for a moment—how do **you** feel about your routine lately? Do you ever feel like the drinking is doing what you want it to do, or does it ever end up creating more stress for you the next day?

PATIENT (Turn 6)

Honestly, most of the time it just feels like a necessary evil. I mean, I go to work, I come home, I drink, I try to get some sleep, and I do it all again the next day. It's not like it's really helping me relax or anything, it's just...I don't know, it's just what I do, I guess. And the next day's always a struggle, but I've learned to just kind of power through it.

THERAPIST (Turn 7)

First of all, thank you for being so honest about that. It takes courage to admit that something isn't really working for you anymore.

Hearing you call it a "necessary evil" really stands out. It sounds like what started as a way to take the edge off has slowly turned into a heavy routine—almost like a hamster wheel you can't step off of. Work, drink, sleep poorly, power through the next day, repeat. That sounds deeply exhausting.

It's interesting, because a few minutes ago, you mentioned this was just about unwinding. But now it sounds like the drinking isn't even giving you that relief anymore; it's just something you **have** to do to get through the night, even though it makes the next day a fight.

"Powering through" every single day takes a massive amount of energy. I'm curious: if you weren't spending so much energy just pushing through the daily grind and the hangovers, what would you actually **want** your life and your evenings to look like?

PATIENT (Turn 8)

(sighs) To be honest, I don't even really know anymore. I mean, it's been so long since I've had a normal night, I don't even remember what that feels like. But sometimes...sometimes I dream about being able to just go home from work and do something I actually enjoy, you know? Like, I used to love reading, but I haven't picked up a book in years. Or watching a movie, or going for a walk. It's like, I've forgotten what relaxation even feels like.

THERAPIST (Turn 9)

I hear how heavy that is. It makes complete sense that you sighed like that—there is a real sadness in realizing you've lost touch with the things that used to bring you joy.

What you're describing is a really common trap. Drinking often promises us relaxation, but over time, it actually steals our ability to feel *true* relaxation. It switches from giving us pleasure to just numbing us out, leaving no room for things like reading a good book, going for a walk, or truly enjoying a movie.

The fact that you still dream about those things—reading, walking, just having a peaceful evening—is actually really important. It tells me that the part of you that loves those things hasn't disappeared. It's just been pushed to the background while you've been in survival mode.

If you take a second to picture the person you were back when you were reading and going for walks... how do you feel toward that version of yourself right now?

PATIENT (Turn 10)

(pauses, looking down) I feel...guilty, I guess. Like, I'm disappointed in myself for letting things get so out of control. And a little angry, too. I mean, I know I'm not the person I used to be, but I don't really know how to get back to that person. I feel like I've failed myself somehow.

THERAPIST (Turn 11)

I can really feel the weight of what you're saying right now. It takes a lot of vulnerability to look down at the floor and admit out loud that you feel disappointed in yourself.

I want to invite you to look at that disappointment from a slightly different angle, if you're open to it.

You only feel disappointed or angry when you deeply care about something. If you had truly given up on yourself, you wouldn't feel guilty—you just wouldn't care. That anger and sadness you're feeling right now? That is the part of you that loves reading, that loves going for walks, and that wants a good life, stepping up and saying, *"Hey, we deserve better than just powering through."*

You haven't failed. What happened is that life got stressful, you used a tool (drinking) to try to handle that stress, and over time, that tool stopped working and started controlling you instead. That happens to so many people—it is a trap, not a character flaw.

You said you don't know how to get back to the person you used to be. But sitting in this room, being this honest, and recognizing that things need to change... that isn't failure. That is literally the very first step of finding your way back.

How does it feel to hear that?

PATIENT (Turn 12)

(looks up, eyes welling up with tears) It feels...it feels like maybe, just maybe, I'm not as lost as I thought. Like, there's still a part of me that remembers who I was, and that's a good feeling. And it's weird, because hearing you say that, it feels like a weight's been lifted off my shoulders. Like, I'm not carrying around all this guilt and shame on my own, that there's someone who sees me and understands what's been going on.

THERAPIST (Turn 13)

I am really moved by your honesty, and I'm so glad you're letting yourself feel that.

That shift you're describing—that feeling of a weight lifting—happens the moment we stop running from the truth and stop carrying the shame all by ourselves. You've been dragging this heavy secret around, powering through every single day, trying to convince everyone (including yourself) that you were fine. That is exhausting.

You *aren't* lost. That person who loves books, who enjoys walks, who wants a peaceful life—that person is right here in this room with me right now. They were just buried under a lot of stress and a habit that took over.

You don't have to do this alone anymore. We don't have to fix your whole life today, either. But now that we're both looking at things clearly, how does it feel to think about us working together to help you get that life back?

PATIENT (Turn 14)

(looks at you with a glimmer of hope in their eyes) It feels...real. Like, it feels like I can actually see a way out of this. And it feels...safe. Like, I'm not going to get judged or lectured or anything. I'm just going to be seen, and heard, and helped. That's a really nice feeling.

THERAPIST (Turn 15)

That is the best thing I could possibly hear. Therapy should never feel like a lecture or a trial; it should be a place where you can take off the armor, stop pretending everything is fine, and just be real.

I want to remind you that **you** made this happen today. You walked in here feeling reluctant, defensive, and overwhelmed, but you chose to be honest. You let yourself look at the hard stuff, and that takes tremendous courage.

We don't need to fix everything overnight, and there won't be any judgment here—only curiosity, support, and practical steps at a pace that feels right for you.

As we wrap up today, how are you feeling about going home tonight? And is there one small, low-pressure thing you might want to do for yourself this evening—even if it's just flipping through a book for five minutes or just taking a breath?

PATIENT (Turn 16)

(takes a deep breath) I'm feeling...more hopeful, I guess. Like, I actually feel like I can take a deep breath and not worry about what's going to happen tomorrow. And as for tonight...I think I might actually try reading something. Even if it's just for five minutes. It's been so long since I've even thought about reading for pleasure, but...it sounds nice. Yeah.

THERAPIST (Turn 17)

That sounds like a wonderful plan. Reading for just five minutes isn't just about reading—it's about taking a tiny piece of your evening back for yourself.

Remember, there's zero pressure. If you read two pages, great. If you read half a page and just hold the book, that's great, too. It's simply a quiet message to yourself that you matter, and that your joy matters.

You did some really brave, heavy lifting today. Be gentle with yourself tonight. You've taken a huge first step, and I'm really looking forward to continuing this work together.

Take care on your way home, and I'll see you next week.

PATIENT (Turn 18)

(smiles slightly) Thanks...I needed to hear that. I'll try to be gentle with myself, at least. (pauses, then nods)
Yeah, see you next week.

THERAPIST (Turn 19)

You're so very welcome. "Gentle" is a wonderful goal for tonight. Just take it one moment at a time.

Have a peaceful evening, and I'll see you next week. Take care.

PATIENT (Turn 20)

(nods, gets up, and walks out of the room, looking a bit more hopeful and a bit more themselves)

THERAPIST (Turn 21)

(Smiles softly as the door closes, taking a quiet moment to reflect on the meaningful progress made today before picking up a pen to write down session notes.)